

The Two Faces of Babylon

Illusion and Ascent in *Mad Men* S1 E6





What is Babylon in 1960?

It is not just a place, but a state of being. It is the glittering promise of the American Dream, embodied by the ambition and commerce of Madison Avenue. **It is a world of immense desire, wealth, and upward mobility.**

But it is also a place of profound spiritual exile, where characters are disconnected from their true selves. In *Sterling Cooper*, everyone is selling something—most of all, a carefully constructed version of themselves.

The Stage is Set: The Precursors to Babylon

The core tensions of Episode 6 are built on foundations laid bare in the episodes before it.



The Failing Ascent (E4: "New Amsterdam"): Pete Campbell's ambition sours into resentment after he mishandles a key account, revealing the fragility of his status.



The Fractured Self (E5: "5G"): Don Draper pays his own brother, Adam Whitman, \$5,000 to disappear, cementing his commitment to the fraudulent "Don Draper" persona over his authentic self, Dick Whitman.

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The Fractured Self (E5: "5GI"): Don Draper's storyline is defined by the "trauma and loneliness" simmering beneath and surface of the hands of the



The Domestic Illusion (E4): Betty Draper's storyline is defined by the "trauma and loneliness" simmering beneath the surface of the '1960s ideal housewife."

Two Paths Through the Gilded City

"Babylon" explores the two fundamental responses to the pressures of 1960s America: maintaining the beautiful, hollow temple of the present, or attempting the perilous climb toward an authentic future.



THE ILLUSION

A life of performance, concealment, and curated surfaces.

Success is defined by maintaining a perfect facade.

Characters: Don Draper, Betty Draper, The Executives.

THE ASCENT

A journey of striving, becoming, and breaking free.

Success is defined by tangible achievement and self-creation.

Character: Peggy Olson.



The Illusion Part I: The Architecture of Masculinity

At Sterling Cooper, masculinity is a performance, and the office is its stage. This world is maintained through a strict code of conduct and appearance.

- **The Uniform:** The men's power is symbolized by their "perfectly tailored suits in classic colors like navy or gray."
- **The Rituals:** The environment is defined by the constant, shared rituals of "drinking and smoking," reinforcing a culture of insider conformity.
- **The Ideology:** The entire structure is propped up by rampant "sexism," which defines the roles and limits of both men and women.



The Price of the Performance

The masculine ideal of Sterling Cooper demands the concealment of any vulnerability or deviation from the norm. The cost of this performance is the denial of the authentic self.

Art director Sal Romano embodies this conflict. As a "closeted homosexual," he must navigate the hyper-masculine and sexist office culture while hiding his true identity.

His presence is a constant, quiet reminder of the profound gap between the performed self and the real self in Babylon.





The Illusion Part II: The Gilded Cage of Suburbia

If Sterling Cooper is the stage for professional illusion, the Draper home in Ossining is the stage for the domestic one. Betty Draper is the central performer in the myth of the happy American family.

Her role as the "1960s ideal housewife" is a full-time job. Her costume of "suburban chic," often featuring "pastel dresses," reinforces an image of delicate, serene perfection. Her home is her temple, meticulously maintained and flawlessly presented.



The Cracks in the Crystal Ball

The perfection is a prison. Betty's story is a slow "dismantling of the illusion of a perfect suburban marriage." Beneath the flawless surface lies a deep well of dissatisfaction and psychological distress. The source material explicitly identifies her core struggles as "loneliness and trauma." The more perfect her world appears, the more isolated she becomes within it.



The Ascent: A Different Path

While the other characters work to maintain their positions within a gilded cage, Peggy Olson begins a genuine climb. She represents a different kind of ambition—not to perform a role, but to create one. Her journey is the central narrative of “ascent” in *Babylon*. It is a rejection of the “traditional path of marriage and motherhood” that society, and women like Betty, have been sold as the ultimate prize.



The Uniform of Invisibility

Peggy's ascent begins from the ground floor. Initially a "naive secretary," her appearance is defined by "humble and conservative outfits." This is not a costume for a grand performance. Unlike the men's tailored suits or Betty's chic dresses, Peggy's clothing is functional, almost invisible.

This lack of a pre-defined role allows her the freedom to move outside the established lines.

Her invisibility becomes her secret weapon, allowing her to observe, learn, and plan her ascent without the burden of maintaining an illusion.



From Secretary to Storyteller

Peggy's power does not come from who she is, but what she can do. Her climb from secretary to copywriter is fueled by "creative and business aspirations." She earns her place not through social maneuvering, but through the merit of her ideas and the quality of her work. In a world built on image, Peggy is building her career on substance.

The Sound of Emptiness

The most telling moment in “Babylon” is what you don’t hear.

The end credits for Episode 6 feature **No Music**.

This deliberate artistic choice is the episode’s final statement. The silence strips away the glamour, the jazz, the seductive soundtrack of the American Dream. What is left is the stark, uncomfortable reality beneath the illusion—the loneliness of the Drapers’ marriage, the quiet desperation in the office, the hollow echo in the halls of Babylon after the selling is done for the day. It is the sound of the dream failing.

Two Destinies in Babylon

The episode leaves its characters on divergent paths.

The Illusionists (Don, Betty, Sal) remain trapped. Their commitment to their constructed selves comes at the cost of genuine connection and inner peace. They have reached the top of their worlds, only to find them empty.



The Ascendant (Peggy) is just beginning her journey. By choosing authenticity and merit over performance, she is building a self, not just playing a part. Her future is uncertain, but it is hers to write.



A man in a dark suit and fedora stands on a rooftop at night, looking out over a city skyline. He is holding a lit cigarette in his right hand. The city lights are visible in the background, with a prominent building featuring a glowing dome. The sky is dark, and the overall atmosphere is contemplative.

In Babylon, the tallest towers often cast the longest shadows.

Mad Men argues that the glittering heights of the **American Dream** are inextricably linked to the **darkness** of what is lost—or sacrificed—to achieve them. The pursuit of illusion creates a void, while the path of true ascent is a climb out of the **shadows**.